

Chapter 37 Part 1

Above the mountain ridges was lush green vegetation that covered the sky and blocked out the sun. Below the cloud peaks were layers of fog that could not disperse, shrouding the entire mountain and tinting the verdant green with a layer of white.

The mountain streams flowed with gurgling water, and occasionally the sounds of wild beasts calling could be heard.

Inside the house.

Qiu Zimin knelt in the proper sitting posture¹.

A middle-aged man dressed in a blue shirt² had brewed a pot of tea. Steam drifted throughout the room. After meticulously wiping his hands, he lowered his eyes and inquired again: "Have you discussed this matter with your husband?"

"Sir, you don't need to beat around the bush. If there's something you want to know, I'll tell you directly." Qiu Zimin lowered her voice: "You only need to say that she can serve as a sacrificial offering, and that once it's done, it will bring prosperity and good fortune to the Liang family. That would be sufficient."

"Madam Liang is truly heartless." The middle-aged man smiled: "But she cannot serve as a sacrificial offering."

Qiu Zimin frowned, "Why not?"

The middle-aged man calmly sipped his tea and said indifferently: "She has two types of fortune on her, one strong and one weak. If the weak one could become strong at this moment, perhaps there would be a need for changing her fortune. But now her luck is obviously too poor. Even if it were changed, it wouldn't benefit the Liang family at all. Moreover, changing fortune is all illusory and ethereal. The way of heaven has its cycles and its own cause and effect. How could it be changed through ritual practices?"

"But since you said it could be changed, then it can be changed." Qiu Zimin said with certainty.

Suddenly, from the clear sky came the desolate cry of a lone eagle, like dozens of airplanes thundering overhead all at once.

The sound was so loud it nearly deafened Liang Shi, and her entire head was buzzing.

The scene before her eyes kept retreating and blurring until everything became dark.

Then a strong light shone in, and Liang Shi suddenly opened her eyes.

It was already morning. Sunlight passed through the gaps in the curtains and refracted into the room, landing right on her pillow.

Liang Shi raised her hand to wipe her forehead. Cold sweat poured down, and even her palms were damp with heat.

Rather than calling it a dream, it was more like something the original body had personally experienced.

She was like an observer watching the young Liang Shi standing in the mountains, while also being able to hear the conversation between Qiu Zimin and the middle-aged man inside the house.

But it had come to an abrupt end.

However, she could confirm that the original body's room was indeed related to sacrifice.

Damn!

Couldn't they eliminate feudal superstition?

Feudal superstition kills people!

Liang Shi looked at her watch. It wasn't time for her alarm to go off yet. Taking advantage of the morning yang energy³, she opened the curtains and then opened the photo gallery, taking out that photograph, trying to discover more clues.

But the background of that photo was too dark, and the photography technology of the past wasn't very advanced either. The pixels were low. After looking at it for a long time, she couldn't make anything out. Later, when she went to wash up, she found it somewhat difficult to look directly at her own face.

By the end of washing her face, she had become somewhat irritated, and two words popped into her mind—bad luck.

Qiu Zimin should know that the original body wasn't her child, and she also harbored hatred toward the original body.

But such a small child—what hatred could she have generated with her?

Was it because of the original body's parents?

But who were the original body's parents? Did Qiu Zimin know?

If she knew, then why didn't she directly take revenge on the adults instead of taking it out on a child?

That meant Qiu Zimin couldn't afford to offend the adults of this family.

But if they were people Qiu Zimin couldn't afford to offend, why were they able to switch out the child?

It was also possible that Qiu Zimin was simply psychologically twisted, so she handed the original body over to Mrs. Qi and made the original body a sacrificial offering.

There were too many possibilities. Question after question tangled in Liang Shi's mind like a ball of yarn with no visible starting thread.

Thinking about it all early in the morning gave Liang Shi such a headache, but she still couldn't figure out anything. These things exceeded her scope of understanding.

After washing up, she slowly went downstairs, thinking that since it was still early today, she should have plenty of time to make breakfast. But when she came downstairs, Xu Qingzhu was already busy in the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu's cooking skills were limited—fried eggs, bread, and soy milk constituted their breakfast for two.

Breakfast was eaten in silence, with both harboring their own thoughts.

Xu Qingzhu had also seen that photograph, but she asked nothing and said nothing. The only thing similar between her and Liang Shi was that they both sported two huge dark circles under their eyes.

Both had spent a sleepless night.

¹ **Kneeling sitting posture (跪坐禮):** A traditional formal sitting position in East Asian cultures where one kneels and sits back on their heels, often used in formal or ceremonial contexts to show respect.

² **Blue shirt (青衫):** A traditional Chinese garment, often associated with scholars or Taoist practitioners in classical literature.

³ **Yang energy (陽氣):** In traditional Chinese philosophy, yang represents the active, masculine, light, and positive principle. Morning is considered a time when yang energy is strongest and most pure.

Chapter 37 Part 2

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Liang Shi had originally planned to drive Xu Qingzhu to the company, but Xu Qingzhu said she had recovered and could drive herself.

So Liang Shi didn't insist.

Before work, Liang Shi bought her usual cup of coffee and encountered Li Ran and Zhou Li when going upstairs.

Li Ran was surprised again, "Little Liang, what's wrong with you? Is your wife still not feeling well?"

Liang Shi: "...She's recovered."

"Your dark circles are too big." Li Ran said: "Didn't you sleep last night?"

Liang Shi helplessly replied, "I slept, but didn't sleep well."

After seeing such terrifying things before bed, anyone would have trouble sleeping.

"Young as you are, how can you already have sleep problems?" Li Ran clicked her tongue, "Why don't you go to the hospital for a check-up?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Even Zhou Li on the side couldn't stand listening anymore and interjected: "Don't you ever stay up late?"

"Does staying up late for overtime count?" Li Ran said: "Usually I go to sleep at ten o'clock."

Zhou Li: "That's different from young people."

"Sister Li, you're also not..." Li Ran's half-sentence "young either" couldn't come out after meeting Zhou Li's death glare, and she could only swallow it silently.

Liang Shi stood to the side, extremely sleepy. She mainly had nightmares all night and had a headache.

"Little Liang." Li Ran changed the subject, "We're going to Yunfeng Mountain¹ to worship gods this week. Are you going?"

"Worship what gods?" Liang Shi asked.

"Just a Taoist temple." Li Ran said: "I heard it's quite effective, especially Master Yunyin². Many rich people go to him for fortune telling and changing their luck."

Liang Shi suddenly perked up, her eyes opening wider than before, "Changing luck?"

"That's right." Li Ran shrugged, "But it's just what I heard. I haven't seen anyone actually succeed. Of course, even if they did, we wouldn't know. There are also rumors that some people keep little ghosts³ at home. There are all sorts of mysterious rumors, but not many people believe them. Besides, after the founding of the nation, spirits aren't allowed to become immortals⁴. These things are just for peace of mind."

Zhou Li said coolly from the side, "I thought you were superstitious to that extent."

"How could that be?" Li Ran laughed awkwardly, "My mom is a firm materialist."

Zhou Li: "But you're not."

Li Ran: "..."

A few seconds later, Li Ran said: "Some things, you can't believe completely, but you can't disbelieve completely either."

She suddenly leaned closer to the two and said in a low voice: "Once before, my little cousin kept crying at night, crying terribly, especially at midnight. This was not long after my grandfather passed away. We took my cousin to the hospital for tests—we did all kinds of examinations but couldn't find anything wrong. Later we found a spirit medium who said she could communicate with spirits. She gave my cousin a bowl of something unknown to drink and performed some ritual at our house. You know what? My cousin stopped crying that very night."

Zhou Li: "...Maybe she was tired from crying."

Li Ran was stumped for a moment, but still said: "I'm not really sure either. According to that spirit medium, my grandfather's soul had returned. My cousin was young with a weak spiritual aura⁵, so she was affected. Adults generally aren't affected."

Zhou Li paused, "What did that spirit medium believe in?"

Li Ran: "...Seemed like Buddhism."

Zhou Li: "Then what are you going to a Taoist temple for?"

Li Ran: "..."

After a while, she muttered: "It doesn't hurt to believe in more things."

Zhou Li scoffed lightly, "When nothing's wrong, no one believes in anything. When something happens, whether it's Eastern gods and Buddhas or Western Jesus, they'll worship them all."

Li Ran: "...That's not without reason either."

Liang Shi listened silently to their conversation while searching for information about Yunfeng Mountain on her phone.

There were pictures of Yunfeng Mountain online, and it looked remarkably similar to the mountain she had seen in her dream last night. But it didn't have the lush mountains and clear waters surrounded by clouds and mist from her dream. It looked like it had been through modern industrialization and lost its original charm.

At the same time, she also searched for Master Yunyin that Li Ran mentioned. There were no pictures online, and very little information.

Most were online inquiries asking whether Master Yunyin of Yunfeng Mountain was effective, and when Master Yunyin would be at the temple.

After the two finished their discussion, Liang Shi asked Li Ran, "Sister Ran, when was that temple you mentioned established?"

"Seven or eight years ago, I think." Li Ran said: "No one had heard of it before, then suddenly there was this thing, and everyone said it was quite effective. What's wrong?"

"Have you ever seen Master Yunyin?" Liang Shi asked.

Li Ran shook her head: "He spends most of his time traveling the world⁶, not at the temple. It's all managed by his young disciple."

Zhou Li suddenly interjected, "When you say he travels the world, does he take planes or fly?"

Li Ran: "...Maybe he takes trains?"

Everyone fell silent together.

Just then the elevator stopped and everyone got out together.

Liang Shi asked: "Sister Ran, which day this week are you going?"

"Sunday morning." Li Ran said: "I'm going with a few people from the variety show department and camera crew."

"Count me in." Liang Shi said: "I'll go get a peace charm⁷."

"Sure thing." Li Ran turned to ask Zhou Li, "Sister Li, are you going?"

Zhou Li waved her hand, leaving them with a carefree silhouette, "I'm staying home to take care of the little one."

¹ **Yunfeng Mountain (雲峰山):** "Cloud Peak Mountain" - a fictional mountain in the story associated with mystical practices.

² **Master Yunyin (雲隱道長):** "Cloud Hidden Taoist Master" - a mysterious Taoist priest who practices fortune telling and feng shui.

³ **Little ghosts (小鬼):** In Chinese folk belief, refers to keeping spirits or supernatural entities for personal gain or protection, often considered a dark practice.

⁴ **After the founding of the nation, spirits aren't allowed to become immortals (建國以後不準成精):** A popular internet meme in China referring to how supernatural stories often end abruptly at 1949 (when the People's Republic of China was founded), suggesting that the new government doesn't allow supernatural beings to exist.

⁵ **Spiritual aura (魂幅):** Refers to one's spiritual strength or resistance to supernatural influences in Chinese folk belief.

⁶ **Traveling the world (雲游四海):** A traditional term for Taoist monks who wander from place to place practicing and teaching.

⁷ **Peace charm (平安符):** Traditional protective talismans sold at temples, believed to bring safety and ward off evil.

Chapter 37 Part 3

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After finishing her work, Liang Shi searched online for information related to Yunfeng Mountain.

The Taoist temple on Yunfeng Mountain was called Yunyin Temple¹, built single-handedly by Master Yunyin ten years ago. It was constructed extremely luxuriously.

This could be seen from the photos online.

At the time, quite a few local media outlets had reported on it, but they were all superficial introductions without specific content.

When Liang Shi searched for Master Yunyin and changing fortune together, she didn't obtain much information.

Just as she was about to close the browser, a pop-up appeared that read [Yunfeng Temple Master Changes Fortune, Leave Your Phone Number——]

Liang Shi hesitated for two seconds, then filled in her phone number. The pop-up then redirected —Write down your needs.

Liang Shi wrote very seriously: [Is it possible to change a family's fortune through sacrificing people?]

The pop-up redirected again——

It froze.

Liang Shi looked at the blank page, where the link kept spinning in circles.

Then her phone suddenly rang. It was a local landline number.

It should be someone from Yunyin Temple contacting her.

Liang Shi immediately answered, "Hello, hi there."

"Hello, hi there. May I ask if you filled in your phone number on an unfamiliar webpage and received calls from unknown numbers?" the other party politely inquired.

Liang Shi responded: "Yes, isn't yours an unknown number too?"

"We just helped you block two numbers." the other party said: "We're calling to remind you not to reveal personal information on unfamiliar webpages, and not to answer calls from numbers that have been flagged multiple times as problematic, as there's a risk of being scammed."

Liang Shi: "...?"

She coughed lightly, "May I ask who you are?"

"This is the Anti-Fraud Center²." the other party said: "Recently, two people have already been defrauded of over ten thousand yuan, so we're calling to remind you."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Please remember to download the Anti-Fraud Center APP." the other party said gently:

"Remember not to browse illegal websites, and especially don't fill in personal information on unfamiliar URLs."

Liang Shi: "..."

She answered nervously: "Okay."

After hanging up, Liang Shi discovered that the webpage on her computer had crashed.

When she tried to go back, the webpage had already become a 404 error.

...

It was quite a novel experience.

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Liang Shi was absent-minded all day because of this incident, and Xu Qingzhu wasn't much better.

The person who usually transformed into a workaholic as soon as she got to work was frequently spacing out today, causing even Sally, who was usually oblivious, to start asking: "Blanche, what are you thinking about? Did you fight with Liang Shi yesterday?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu took a sip of coffee and pressed her temples, "Continue."

After struggling through the meeting, Xu Qingzhu leaned back in her chair thinking about that photograph from last night.

She had been too nervous at the time and didn't remember many details, but Liang Shi's face was deeply imprinted in her mind, making her afraid to look at Liang Shi this morning.

Xu Qingzhu had heard about some sacrifice-related matters before, but they were generally wealthy family secrets, and you'd need to find a truly skilled master to accomplish such things.

Had the Liang family done this?

If they really had, why would they continue to decline?

Shouldn't they be rising steadily?

Moreover, Dongheng Group had always developed normally. In the past when the luxury goods industry wasn't well-developed, Dongheng Group could dominate alone, but now with the world changing rapidly, luxury brands increasing, and international competition intensifying, it was normal for Dongheng Group's market share to decrease.

Or was it that the Liang family had tried to go against the trend but failed?

Unable to figure it out, Xu Qingzhu sent a message to Zhao Xuning: [Do you know about sacrificial offerings?]

Zhao Xuning: [...Believe in science.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Sweating emoji.jpg]

Xu Qingzhu organized her words before saying: [I mean using people as sacrificial offerings to exchange for things, like family fortune or exchanging lives.]

Zhao Xuning quickly connected this to Liang Shi: [You mean Liang Shi had her life exchanged?]

Xu Qingzhu: [...It's possible.]

Zhao Xuning: [I still lean more toward her having amnesia.]

Xu Qingzhu: [I've heard before about sacrificing people to change family fortune.]

Zhao Xuning: [The last person who did that ended up with his family destroyed.]

Xu Qingzhu: [?]

Zhao Xuning: [Do you know Dingsheng Manufacturing Company³? They used to make metal products. They found a master to read feng shui and change their fortune, tortured his daughter until she went crazy, then his daughter jumped off a building, his wife died in an accident, his three-year-old son drowned, and he himself tripped while walking on the road and fell into a sewer and died too.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...]

Xu Qingzhu searched online and found many reports about this company, though they were all about the company's peak period. After they went bankrupt and family members died one by one, there wasn't much news.

Xu Qingzhu: [Didn't you say to believe in science?]

Zhao Xuning: [Because of him, my dad almost went to find someone to read feng shui and change our house.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Do you know who he found?]

Zhao Xuning: [The one on Yunfeng Mountain. He suddenly built a temple back then and was hyped up tremendously.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...Got it.]

From Zhao Xuning, she not only learned about Yunfeng Mountain but also some secrets within their circle.

Many wealthy families would find Master Yunyin to read feng shui. As for changing fortune, that hadn't been done before. Supposedly Master Yunyin didn't do it—after all, everyone was rich, and if you wanted to change yours and I wanted to change mine, wouldn't that cause ecological imbalance in the end? So he just looked at grave feng shui and examined company layouts, and most of the time it was effective.

It was said that Dingsheng's incident back then was because the man felt sorry for his daughter and asked to stop midway through Master Yunyin's fortune-changing process, which resulted in a backlash.

However, things in their circle were three parts truth and seven parts fiction. Zhao Xuning told her there was no need to believe it all.

The Liang family had always been fairly normal in business, not taking those crooked paths.

As for what they did privately, that was unknown.

Zhao Xuning didn't really believe in life-exchanging anyway. She believed in—science.

Of course Xu Qingzhu didn't believe it either, but after seeing that photograph, she always felt this should be related to Liang Shi's changes.

Although from the photo it wasn't something that had just happened, it must have had a huge impact during Liang Shi's growth process.

Especially that smile—Xu Qingzhu had seen it when she was restless and agitated.

When she was restless and agitated, she would frantically try to get close to her, and if she didn't allow it, she would slam the door and leave.

The next day when she returned, she would definitely carry the scent of other women's cosmetics.

After researching everything, Xu Qingzhu decided to find time to visit Yunfeng Mountain and see for herself.

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Ever since receiving the call from the Anti-Fraud Center, Liang Shi had been very well-behaved.

She didn't dare search for that matter online at all, not until she got off work.

Zhao Ying, who had barely exchanged a few words with her on WeChat, suddenly sent her a message: [Are you busy lately?]

Liang Shi: [Not too bad. Sister Ying, what's up?]

Zhao Ying: [Laughing emoji.jpg Your sweet talk is quite good.]

Zhao Ying sent a voice message: "I have a role here, missing a third female lead⁴. Are you interested in auditioning?"

¹ **Yunyin Temple (雲隱觀)**: "Cloud Hidden Temple" - the mysterious Taoist temple on Yunfeng Mountain.

² **Anti-Fraud Center (反詐中心)**: A real government initiative in China that actively contacts citizens to prevent telecommunications fraud.

³ **Dingsheng Manufacturing Company (鼎晟制造公司)**: A fictional company used as an example of the consequences of attempting supernatural fortune changes.

⁴ **Third female lead (女三號)**: In Chinese entertainment industry terminology, refers to the third most important female role in a production, after the first and second female leads.